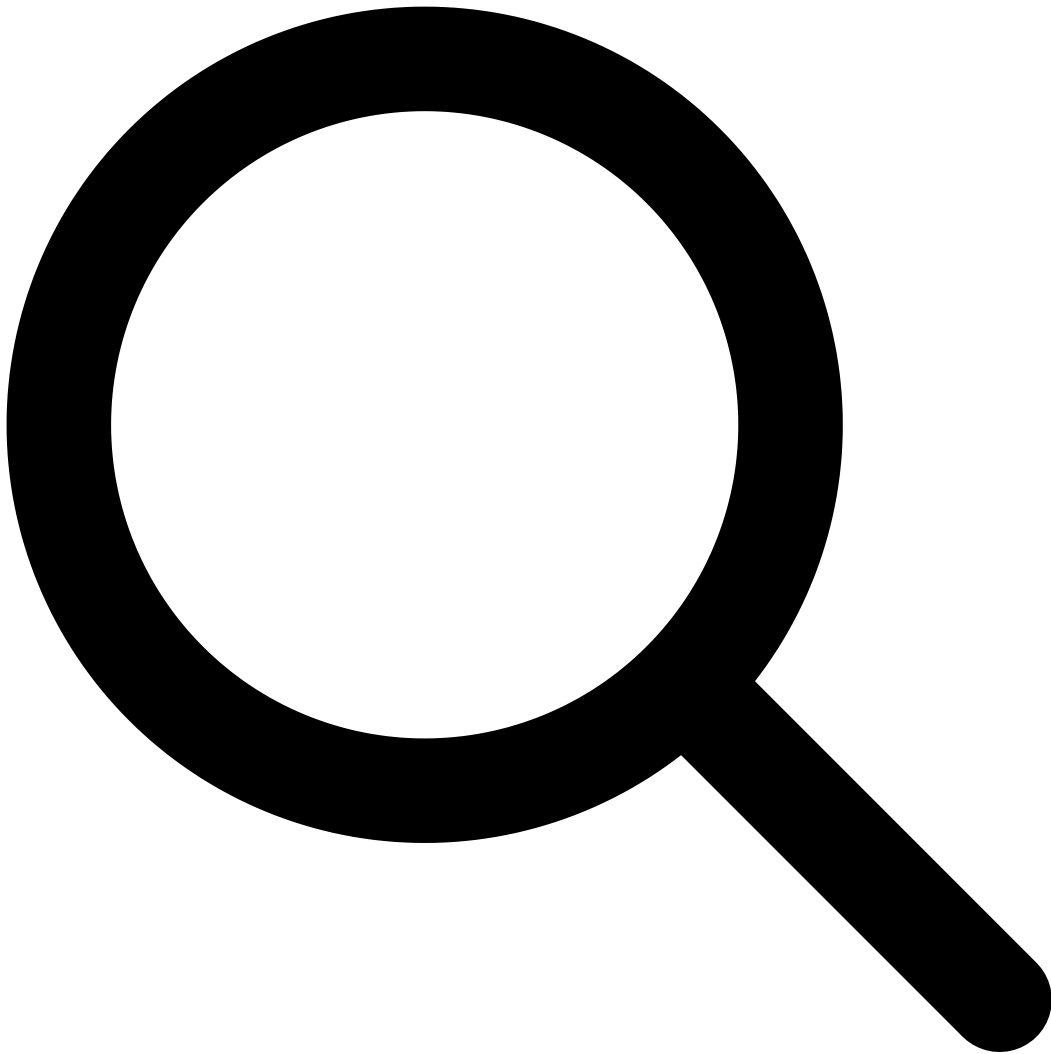


[Skip to Content](#)



⌘K

[Trevor Lam](#) (/)

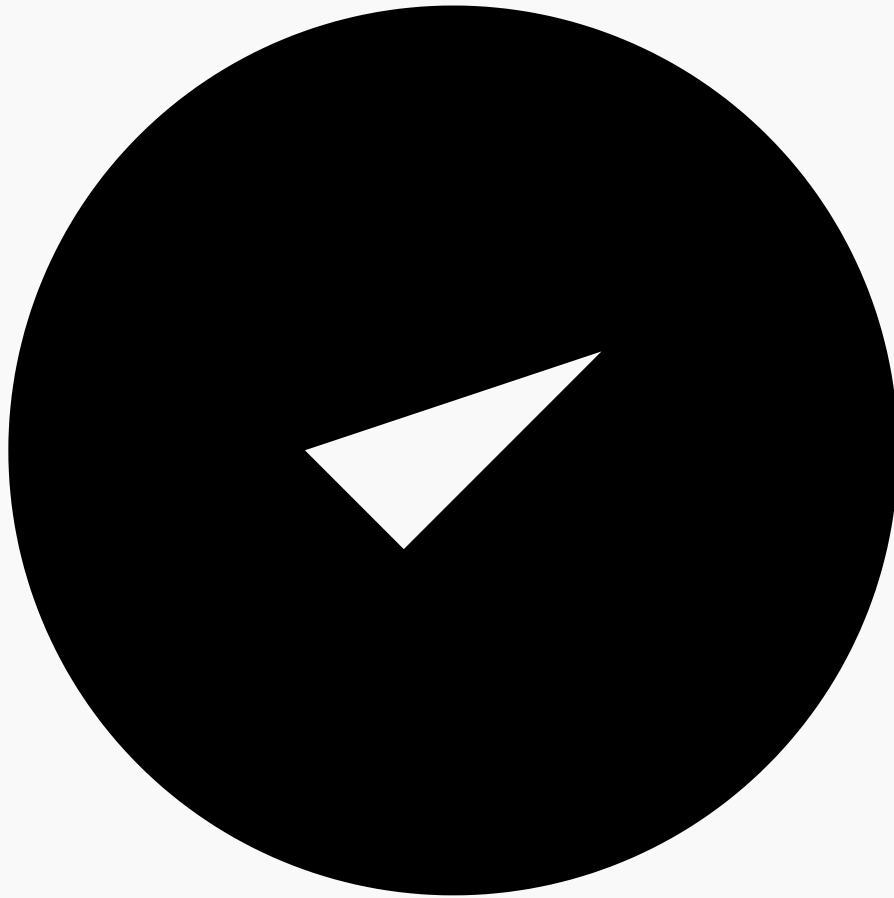
CPA-Payroll

# Scaling Multi-Entity Operations: Payroll, HR, and Digital Transformation at a CPA & Payroll Firm

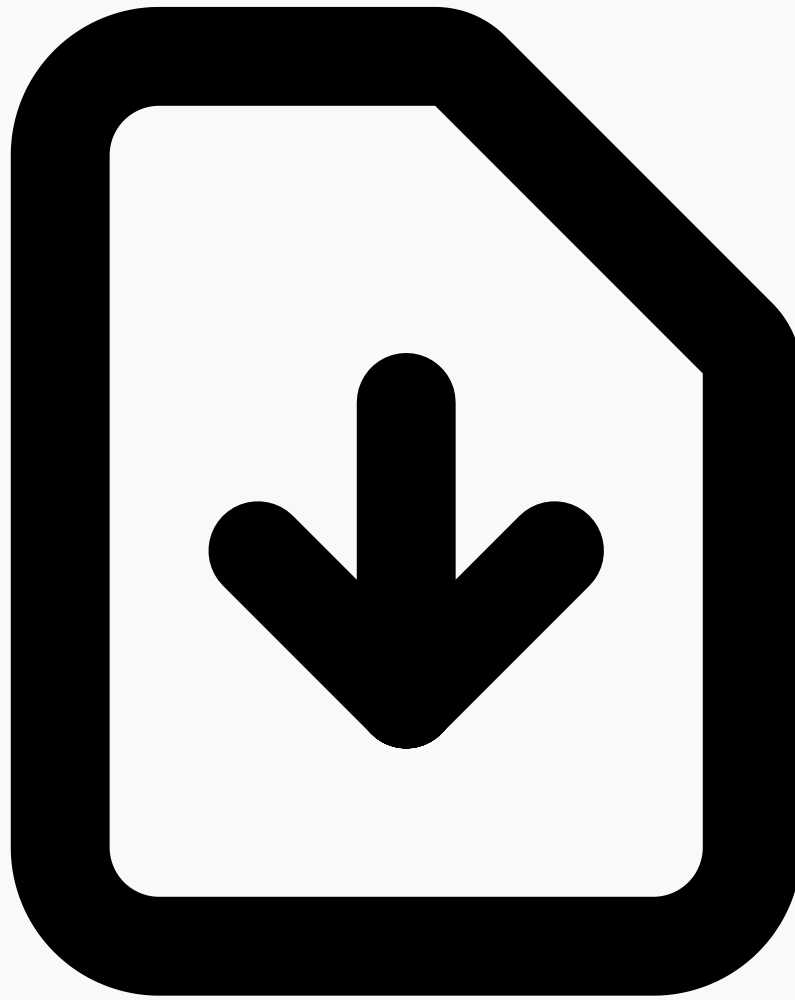
---



Last updated: January 24, 2024



Case verified



# **K.L.W. Financial Group: Running Operations for Three Companies at Once**

---

## **Operational Context**

---

**Three Legally Distinct Entities, One Operational Reality:**

- **K.L.W. Financial Group** (umbrella holding company)
- **Walton CPA PC** (CPA practice)
- **Your Payroll Department LLC** (payroll services company)

Each had separate clients, separate regulatory exposure, separate operations—but one shared office and staff. Managing three entities is exponentially harder than two.

**My path:** Administrative Assistant (2 months) → Executive Assistant (promoted in 60 days) → Integrator (#2 operational role, 18 months)

## Starting Point

---

- **Hybrid paper-and-electronic dependency** choking month-end close
- **~20 vendors** across both active firms requiring coordination
- **Zero single operational owner** across three entities
- **Compliance exposure** across 315+ payroll client data environment
- **280-315+ payroll client accounts** managed through APEX on biweekly cycles
- **~200 tax return workflows** through Thomson Reuters and SafeSend
- **85-100 CPA clients** supported across bookkeeping functions

## The Promotion Mechanism (Documented Behavioral Pattern)

---

**Same mechanism that drove every Sonic promotion:**

1. Consistently finished work ahead of pace
2. Explicitly asked for more responsibility
3. Was promoted based on demonstrated pace and quality

**Why the fast promotions?**

- **First promotion in 60 days** — from entry-level to Executive Assistant at a CPA firm where the principals are trained skeptics. Fastest promotion I've ever earned.
- **Second promotion to Integrator** — effectively the #2 role, running operations when principals were unavailable.

## The Methodology

---

### Phase 1: Month-End Close Restructuring

- Eliminated hybrid paper-and-electronic dependency
- Created audit readiness across three entities
- Improved efficiency and organization
- Quality assurance metrics implementation

### Phase 2: Paper-to-Digital Transition

**This was organizational change, not technical migration:**

- Process redesign requiring stakeholder buy-in
- Sustained adoption management
- SOPs, checklists, templates across all three entities
- Workflow documentation for operational continuity

### Phase 3: Scope Expansion Until Title Matched Role

Took on expanding responsibilities until formally titled as Integrator:

- Client onboarding system setup
- Independent direct collections (past-due clients under own authority)
- Staff training for all new hires
- Independent external client communication
- First-line IT contact (functionally operating under IRS Publication 4557 and FTC Safeguards Rule)
- Marketing operations (HubSpot, ActiveCampaign, Google Ads, Google Business Profile)
- B2B event-driven demand generation (filled rooms for public speaking events)

## The Outcome

---

### Quantitative Results

- **Promotion Velocity:** Entry level → Integrator (#2 role) in 18 months
- **First Promotion:** 60 days (fastest in career record)
- **Client Scale:** 280-315+ payroll accounts, ~200 tax workflows, 85-100 CPA clients
- **Digital Transition:** Full paper-to-digital recordkeeping across three entities
- **Audit Readiness:** Achieved across multi-entity environment

### Trust Achievements

- **Zero confidentiality breaches** while handling HR records, P&L data, tax returns, and payroll with full bank/Social Security details
- **Zero conflicts of interest** across three legally distinct entities with potentially overlapping interests
- My Notary Public credential adds a legally-binding confidentiality layer

## Systems Managed

QBO, Xero, APEX Payroll, Thomson Reuters, SafeSend, Karbon, HubSpot, ActiveCampaign, Google Ads, Google Business Profile, Google Search Console, Excel (pivot tables, VLOOKUPS, reconciliations), Microsoft Office, Google Workspace, Zoom

## Skills Demonstrated

---

- **Multi-Entity Operations:** Managing 3 legally distinct firms simultaneously
- **Trust Compression:** 60-day first promotion at analytically-trained skeptic firm
- **Paper-to-Digital Transition:** Organizational change across 3 entities
- **Payroll Service Bureau Operations:** 280-315+ client accounts, biweekly cycles
- **Independent Authority:** Collections, client communication, IT decisions without principal approval
- **Chain-of-Custody Management:** Zero breaches across high-sensitivity data environment

## What This Role Proved

---

This job showed I can:

- Earn trust fast, even with skeptical professionals
- Navigate complex multi-entity operations without errors
- Lead organizational change initiatives (paper-to-digital)
- Run operations independently when principals are unavailable
- Keep sensitive information secure across potentially competing interests
- Use the same approach that worked at Sonic: deliver results, ask for more, earn the promotion

**The reality:** Most law firms prohibit serving multiple principals with overlapping interests. I did it for two years across three entities from one office with zero ethical issues. That's not a typical professional services background.

© 2026 Trevor Lam. All rights reserved.



Available for Operations, Chief of Staff, and HR/Payroll opportunities.

[LinkedIn](https://linkedin.com/in/trevor-lam) (<https://linkedin.com/in/trevor-lam>), [Email](mailto:trevor@trevor-lam.com) (<mailto:trevor@trevor-lam.com>).